

Supplemental Material for “Roton-like Reconstruction of the Emergent Photon in Quantum Spin Ice”

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THEORETICAL RESPONSE AND RELATION TO NEUTRON SCATTERING

The quantity calculated in the Letter is the zero-temperature, sublattice-summed longitudinal pseudospin correlation function

$$S^{zz}(\mathbf{q}, \omega) = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{\mu, n} |\langle n | S_{\mu}^z(\mathbf{q}) | 0 \rangle|^2 \delta(\omega - \omega_n), \quad (1)$$

where

$$S_{\mu}^z(\mathbf{q}) = \sum_{i \in \mu} e^{-i\mathbf{q} \cdot \mathbf{r}_i} S_i^z \quad (2)$$

and μ runs over the four pyrochlore sublattices.

Inside the spin-ice manifold, S_i^z is the component of the pseudospin along the local $\langle 111 \rangle$ easy axis and equals the emergent electric field,

$$E_i = S_i^z. \quad (3)$$

Every quoted spectral fraction is normalized at fixed momentum:

$$Z_n(\mathbf{q}) = \frac{\sum_{\mu} |\langle n | S_{\mu}^z(\mathbf{q}) | 0 \rangle|^2}{\sum_{m, \mu} |\langle m | S_{\mu}^z(\mathbf{q}) | 0 \rangle|^2}. \quad (4)$$

Equation (1) is not by itself the laboratory neutron cross section. A material-specific magnetic cross section contains the ionic form factor, the g tensor, the rotation between the four local $\langle 111 \rangle$ frames and the laboratory frame, the neutron polarization tensor

$$\delta_{\alpha\beta} - \hat{q}_{\alpha} \hat{q}_{\beta}, \quad (5)$$

and coherent interference between different sublattices.

Schematically,

$$I(\mathbf{q}, \omega) \propto \sum_{\mu\nu} \mathcal{F}_{\mu\nu}(\mathbf{q}) S_{\mu\nu}^{zz}(\mathbf{q}, \omega), \quad (6)$$

where

$$S_{\mu\nu}^{zz}(\mathbf{q}, \omega) = \sum_n \langle 0 | S_{\mu}^z(-\mathbf{q}) | n \rangle \langle n | S_{\nu}^z(\mathbf{q}) | 0 \rangle \delta(\omega - \omega_n). \quad (7)$$

The 50–54% low-mode fractions quoted in the Letter therefore refer strictly to the sublattice-summed pseudospin response. They are not universal neutron-intensity fractions. A material-specific prediction requires applying the coherent projection appropriate to the material’s local axes and g tensor.

CONTRACTIBLE RING TERMS AND FINITE CLUSTERS

The Hamiltonian is

$$H = -K \sum_p (W_p + W_p^{\dagger}), \quad W_p = S_1^+ S_2^- S_3^+ S_4^- S_5^+ S_6^-. \quad (8)$$

On a periodic finite cluster, six-site closed paths come in two classes: elementary contractible hexagons corresponding to plaquettes of the infinite pyrochlore lattice, and loops that close only by winding around the torus. The latter are not local plaquettes of the thermodynamic Hamiltonian. We therefore compute the winding vector of every six-cycle and retain only zero-winding elementary hexagons.

For every cluster used in the Letter, the retained Hamiltonian has the full lattice density of elementary rings.

The principal finite clusters are

	$2 \times 2 \times 3$	$2 \times 2 \times 4$	$2 \times 3 \times 3$	$2 \times 3 \times 4$
sites	48	64	72	96
ice configurations	87 546	2 756 394	12 846 186	2 007 260 562
spectral sector dimension	9 104	249 180	973 008	146 758 352

The commonly used 16- and 32-site pyrochlore clusters are pathological for the present dynamical question. On the 32-site cell every configuration in the connected zero-flux sector has exactly eight flippable hexagons. The equal-amplitude state is consequently an exact eigenstate and the spectrum becomes artificially integer-like. On the 16-site cluster only six transport sectors possess nontrivial ring dynamics. We therefore begin with 48 sites.

Varying cluster shape at fixed spin number is also not a clean option. At these sizes, alternative thin tori containing an L -type momentum lose a substantial fraction of the contractible elementary rings. For example, the $1 \times 3 \times 4$ 48-site cell contains only 24 contractible hexagons. Keeping only those terms produces a Hamiltonian with half the ring density and therefore a different microscopic model. The finite-size analysis consequently uses the sequence of admissible clusters listed above.

WINDING SECTORS

The ring Hamiltonian conserves topological winding polarization. Configurations are assigned an exact integer key derived from

$$\mathbf{P} = \sum_i \left(n_i - \frac{1}{2} \right) \mathbf{r}_i. \quad (9)$$

On the 48-site cluster all winding sectors can be enumerated explicitly. The global ground state lies in the sector of dimension 9104 used for complete diagonalization.

On 72 sites the zero-polarization sector is empty. The ground states instead form a degenerate $\pm \mathbf{P}$ pair of nonzero-polarization sectors, each of dimension

$$973\,008 \quad (10)$$

and energy

$$E_0 = -14.80971536K. \quad (11)$$

The identification is verified by explicit diagonalization rather than inferred, and on the two clusters where the winding sectors can be enumerated in full the verification is exhaustive.

On the 48-site cluster all 155 sectors were diagonalized. The ground state lies in the sector of largest dimension (9104), and the lowest energy of any other sector is higher by $0.988K$. On the 72-site cluster all 310 sectors were diagonalized. The ground energy is attained in the two largest sectors (973 008 states each), which are the exactly degenerate $\pm \mathbf{P}$ pair related by spin reversal, and the lowest energy of any sector outside that pair is higher by $0.998K$.

These exhaustive checks also establish what cannot be assumed. Sector energy is *not* monotone in sector dimension: on the 72-site cluster a sector of dimension 401 724 lies at $-13.811K$, below sectors of dimension 498 654 at $-13.746K$. Dimension is therefore not a variational argument, and we do not use it as one.

At 96 sites, where 519 sectors exist and exhaustive diagonalization is out of reach, the twelve largest candidates were diagonalized directly. The lowest is the sector of dimension 146 758 352 used throughout, at $E_0 = -19.5679K$, with the next distinct energy higher by $0.375K$. Across those twelve, sector energy rises steadily as the dimension falls—from $-19.568K$ at 1.47×10^8 states to between $-18.2K$ and $-18.6K$ at 5.5×10^7 —so a sector outside the twelve, every one of which is smaller still, would have to be a dramatic outlier to lie lower. That is evidence rather than proof: all quantities reported at 96 sites refer to the lowest sector among those tested, and the exhaustive results at 48 and 72 sites, where the largest sector does contain the ground state by an $O(1)K$ margin, are what make it the physically relevant one.

ENUMERATION AND LANCZOS SPECTROSCOPY

Ice configurations are enumerated exactly by assigning spins sequentially and backtracking whenever a tetrahedron would acquire three spins of either sign. For every elementary hexagon, a bit mask and its two alternating flippable patterns identify the states connected by the ring Hamiltonian.

On 48 sites the 9104-dimensional sector is diagonalized completely with a dense symmetric eigensolver. All eigenvalues and eigenvectors are therefore available.

At 64 sites the sector dimension is 249 180. The dynamical response is obtained through Lanczos continued fractions seeded independently by

$$S_\mu^z(\mathbf{q})|0\rangle. \quad (12)$$

The 64-site calculation uses full reorthogonalization.

Going beyond 64 spins requires replacing the single-word bit representation. For 72 and 96 sites, each configuration is represented by a pair of 64-bit words. All masking, flipping, sorting, and exact lookup operations are implemented on the word pair.

The two-word pipeline is validated on the 48-site cluster, where it reproduces

$$E_0 = -10.55601176K, \quad (13)$$

$$S(L) = 0.37036, \quad (14)$$

and the principal L energies

$$1.0235K, \quad 1.7303K \quad (15)$$

exactly relative to the single-word implementation.

On 96 sites the complete ice manifold contains

$$2\,007\,260\,562 \quad (16)$$

configurations. It is enumerated using a vectorized frontier algorithm that imposes one tetrahedron constraint at a time and branches the frontier into independent seeds. The spectral sector contains

$$146\,758\,352 \quad (17)$$

basis states and approximately

$$2.7 \times 10^9 \quad (18)$$

nonzero Hamiltonian matrix elements.

The continued-fraction calculation uses real Lanczos separately on the real and imaginary parts of the probe. This is exact for a real symmetric Hamiltonian and reduces Krylov storage. On the 72-site cluster, 120 real iterations reproduce the 250-iteration complex calculation to every printed digit.

Degenerate eigenvalues are grouped within

$$10^{-8}K \quad (19)$$

and their spectral weights summed before branch weights are quoted. Only the total weight of a degenerate multiplet is basis invariant.

Momentum labels are certified by explicit translation projectors rather than inferred from an ordering of the numerical eigenstates.

Three exact gates are applied throughout:

1. the plaquette-energy identity

$$\sum_p \langle W_p + W_p^\dagger \rangle = -\frac{E_0}{K}, \quad (20)$$

2. agreement of the spectral first moment with the exact double-commutator result, and

3. the gauge identity

$$Cd_0 = 0 \quad (21)$$

for the lattice curl.

Krylov convergence at 96 sites

Full reorthogonalization against all previously generated Krylov vectors is performed at every iteration and at every cluster size; no selective or partial scheme is used, and the Lanczos basis is retained in memory for that purpose. The equal-time sum rule is applied as a normalization gate, but it does not by itself certify individual poles, so the 96-site spectra were recomputed independently at two Krylov dimensions, $m = 120$ and $m = 200$, and compared line by line.

The two dominant lines at each of the two inequivalent L classes — the levels carrying all quantities used in this paper — are converged to machine precision. At the reconstructing class,

	ω/K	Z	$d\omega/dV$	
$m = 120$	0.904043	0.192939	+0.25927	
$m = 200$	0.904043	0.192939	+0.25927	(22)
$m = 120$	1.647098	0.079920	+0.13465	
$m = 200$	1.647098	0.079920	+0.13465	

with $|\Delta\omega| = 0$ and $|\Delta Z| < 5 \times 10^{-17}$; at the nonreconstructing class the corresponding differences are $|\Delta\omega| < 4 \times 10^{-15}$ and $|\Delta Z| < 8 \times 10^{-16}$. The third line at each momentum, carrying between 1 and 2% of the weight, agrees to between 10^{-11} and 10^{-6} in energy. The ground-state energy and $\langle n^{\text{flip}} \rangle$ are identical in the two runs to all printed digits, as is $S(\mathbf{q})$.

Beyond the third line the individual Ritz values are *not* converged, and we say so: each carries less than one percent of the weight, and their ordering differs between the two runs. This is the expected behaviour of a Lanczos continued fraction, whose tail represents integrated high-energy weight rather than resolved individual poles. No statement in this paper depends on those lines; the off-pole weight is quoted only as an aggregate.

GAUSSIAN LATTICE ELECTRODYNAMICS

Every comparison with a “Gaussian photon” is made using the lattice curl on the same finite torus as the microscopic calculation.

Write

$$B_p = \sum_{\ell} C_{p\ell} A_{\ell}, \quad (23)$$

where C is the alternating lattice curl. Expanding the compact magnetic energy to quadratic order and introducing the electric stiffness gives

$$H_G = \frac{U}{2} \sum_{\ell} E_{\ell}^2 + K \sum_p B_p^2, \quad [A_{\ell}, E_{\ell'}] = i\delta_{\ell\ell'}. \quad (24)$$

At fixed momentum, the normal-mode frequencies are determined by the nonzero singular values of the curl block,

$$\omega_{\lambda}(\mathbf{q}) = \sqrt{2UK} \sigma_{\lambda}(\mathbf{q}). \quad (25)$$

The construction satisfies three checks:

1. gauge invariance,

$$Cd_0 = 0 \quad (26)$$

to machine precision;

2. exactly two nonzero singular values for every $\mathbf{q} \neq \Gamma$ and none at Γ ;
3. orthonormality and completeness of the Bloch basis.

Exact degeneracy of the transverse doublet

A property of Eq. (25) that the Letter uses as its reference point deserves to be stated separately, because it is what makes the measured splitting a qualitative rather than a quantitative statement. At every momentum of every cluster we examined, the two nonzero singular values are not merely both present but *equal* to machine precision,

$$\sigma_1(\mathbf{q}) = \sigma_2(\mathbf{q}) \quad \text{for all } \mathbf{q} \neq \Gamma, \quad (27)$$

so the Gaussian transverse doublet is exactly degenerate throughout the zone. Representative values on the 48-site cluster are $\sigma = 3$ at $(\frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{3})$, $2\sqrt{3} = 3.4641016151$ at L , $\sqrt{15} = 3.8729833462$ at $(\frac{1}{6}, \frac{1}{6}, \frac{5}{6})$, $\sqrt{13}$ at $(\frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{2}{3})$, and 4 at X , each appearing twice with the remaining singular values below 10^{-15} . The agreement between the two members is at the level of the singular-value solver, $\lesssim 10^{-15}$ relative.

The consequence is the one the Letter draws. The parameters U and K enter Eq. (25) only through the overall prefactor $\sqrt{2UK}$, which multiplies both members identically. Renormalizing the Gaussian theory—by any amount, in either parameter, at any momentum-independent strength—therefore rescales the doublet without splitting it. A nonzero splitting cannot be produced within Gaussian lattice electrodynamics at all, and its observation is not a quantitative correction to that description but a failure of it. This is why the branch ratio $\omega_{\text{low}}/\omega_{\text{high}}$ is used in the Letter as a scale-free diagnostic: its Gaussian value is unity for every choice of parameters, so any deviation is a pure interaction effect, and unlike the softening $\omega_{\text{low}}/\omega_G$ it does not require the fitted scale $\sqrt{2UK} = 0.5868K$ at all.

We emphasize that the degeneracy is a statement about the Gaussian theory on these tori, verified numerically at every momentum we use, and not a symmetry argument we have proved in general. Nothing in the Letter requires more than the verified statement.

The pure ring Hamiltonian contains no independent bare value of U , so one overall scale must be inferred from the interacting spectrum. A single linear least-squares fit gives

$$\sqrt{2UK} = 0.5868K. \quad (28)$$

At L this gives

$$\omega_G(L) = 2.03K. \quad (29)$$

The fitted curve is used only to quantify the magnitude of the reconstruction and to compare momentum dependence. The scale-free branch ratio and spectral-weight fractions quoted in the Letter do not depend on this fit.

BASIS-INVARIANT TRANSVERSE-CHANNEL RESOLUTION

At each momentum the electric-field probe spans the four-dimensional sublattice space. The lattice curl has rank two, leaving a two-dimensional transverse physical subspace. The residual weight in the remaining longitudinal directions is less than

$$10^{-31} \quad (30)$$

relative to $S(\mathbf{q})$.

The two Gaussian singular values are exactly degenerate, so an individual transverse basis is defined only up to a rotation. Statements assigning a level to a particular arbitrarily chosen Gaussian polarization are therefore not invariant.

For a level of multiplicity m , let A_n be the $m \times 2$ matrix of amplitudes in any orthonormal transverse basis. We define

$$M_n = A_n^\dagger A_n. \quad (31)$$

The polarization purity is

$$\mathcal{P}_n = \frac{\text{tr } M_n^2}{(\text{tr } M_n)^2}, \quad (32)$$

and the normalized overlap between two levels is

$$\mathcal{O}_{AB} = \frac{\text{tr}(M_A M_B)}{\text{tr } M_A \text{tr } M_B}. \quad (33)$$

Both quantities are invariant under rotations of the transverse basis.

Representative 48-site results are

$\mathbf{q}$	ω_1/K	ω_2/K	splitting	overlap
$(\frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{3})$	1.895	1.980	0.044	2×10^{-28}
$(\frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{2}{3})$	1.744	2.069	0.171	10^{-29}
$(\frac{1}{6}, \frac{1}{6}, \frac{5}{6})$	2.533	2.687	0.059	4×10^{-2}
L	1.024	1.730	0.513	3×10^{-3}
X	2.235	3.423	0.420	10^{-31}

The two brightest levels are nearly orthogonal directions within the two-dimensional transverse probe space. We use this result to speak operationally of two transverse S^z -active branches. The polarization geometry by itself is not taken as proof of an adiabatic quasiparticle ancestry.

EXACT FIRST MOMENT AND FEYNMAN RATIO

The first spectral moment is

$$f_1(\mathbf{q}) = \frac{1}{2N} \sum_{\mu} \langle 0 | [S_{\mu}^z(-\mathbf{q}), [H, S_{\mu}^z(\mathbf{q})]] | 0 \rangle. \quad (34)$$

For the ring Hamiltonian this reduces exactly to

$$f_1(\mathbf{q}) = \frac{K}{2N} \sum_p \langle W_p + W_p^{\dagger} \rangle \sum_{\mu} |g_p^{\mu}(\mathbf{q})|^2. \quad (35)$$

The zeroth moment is

$$S(\mathbf{q}) = \int d\omega S^{zz}(\mathbf{q}, \omega), \quad (36)$$

and the ratio of the two is

$$\omega_F(\mathbf{q}) = \frac{f_1(\mathbf{q})}{S(\mathbf{q})}. \quad (37)$$

Why the ratio is a bound and not merely a centroid

Equation (37) admits two readings, and only the second carries evidential weight.

The first is that ω_F is the centroid of $S^{zz}(\mathbf{q}, \omega)$ —the first moment divided by the zeroth. Read this way the quantity is a summary of a spectrum, and once that spectrum has been computed it says nothing the spectrum does not already say. A low centroid at a momentum whose spectrum we have diagonalized is a restatement of the low pole, not evidence for it.

The second reading is the operative one. Let

$$|\psi_{\mathbf{q}}\rangle = \frac{S^z(\mathbf{q})|0\rangle}{\sqrt{S(\mathbf{q})}}, \quad (38)$$

which is normalized and, for $\mathbf{q} \neq \Gamma$, orthogonal to the ground state because $S^z(\mathbf{q})$ carries nonzero momentum. Then

$$\langle \psi_{\mathbf{q}} | H - E_0 | \psi_{\mathbf{q}} \rangle = \frac{\langle 0 | S^z(-\mathbf{q}) (H - E_0) S^z(\mathbf{q}) | 0 \rangle}{\langle 0 | S^z(-\mathbf{q}) S^z(\mathbf{q}) | 0 \rangle} = \frac{f_1(\mathbf{q})}{S(\mathbf{q})}, \quad (39)$$

the numerator being $\sum_n \omega_n | \langle n | S^z(\mathbf{q}) | 0 \rangle |^2 = f_1$ by definition. So ω_F is the variational energy of an explicit trial state, and by the Rayleigh–Ritz principle applied within the subspace orthogonal to $|0\rangle$,

$$\omega_F(\mathbf{q}) \geq \omega_{\min}(\mathbf{q}), \quad (40)$$

where $\omega_{\min}$ is the lowest excitation at $\mathbf{q}$ odd under global spin reversal. This is a rigorous inequality, and both sides of Eq. (37) are ground-state expectation values. A small ω_F therefore *certifies* the existence of a low-lying odd excitation at that momentum without any excited state having been computed. That is the sense in which the quantity is used.

The bound is not tight, and we do not present it as one. At L on the 48-site cluster $\omega_F = 1.846K$ against a true lowest excitation of $1.024K$, an overestimate of 80%, because the centroid is pulled up by the high-energy weight in the same channel. What survives the looseness is the *ordering*, which is the use we make of it.

The ratio ranks the momenta correctly

Because ω_F grows with $|\mathbf{q}|$ for trivial reasons, momenta at different $|\mathbf{q}|$ are compared after normalizing by the Gaussian energy $\omega_G = \sqrt{2UK}\sigma$ at the single fitted scale of Sec. . Table I collects every momentum resolved at 48 sites.

TABLE I. Ground-state predictor against measured softening, all momenta resolved at 48 sites. The predictor ω_F/ω_G is built entirely from ground-state data; $\omega_{\text{low}}/\omega_G$ is measured from the diagonalized spectrum. The two columns order the five momenta identically.

$\mathbf{q}$	$ \mathbf{q} $	$S(\mathbf{q})$	$f_1(\mathbf{q})$	ω_F/ω_G	$\omega_{\text{low}}/\omega_G$
L	0.866	0.3704	0.6835	0.908	0.503
$(\frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{2}{3})$	0.816	0.2870	0.7150	1.177	0.824
X	1.000	0.2727	0.8790	1.373	0.952
$(\frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{3})$	0.577	0.1894	0.4585	1.375	1.076
$(\frac{1}{6}, \frac{1}{6}, \frac{5}{6})$	0.866	0.2583	0.8306	1.415	1.114

The two orderings agree on all five entries, with no inversions: the Spearman rank correlation is exactly +1. Neither column is ordered by $|\mathbf{q}|$, which is the point of including that column: the first and last rows sit on the same shell $|\mathbf{q}| = 0.866$ and are separated by the predictor (0.908 against 1.415) exactly as they are separated by the measurement (0.503 against 1.114). The predictor is therefore not a proxy for wavevector magnitude. The predictor separates the two momenta that soften (0.908, 1.177) from the three that do not (1.373–1.415) by a clear gap, and within the softening pair it places L first, which is where the reconstruction is largest. This is the sense in which the ground-state ratio locates the reconstruction rather than merely describing it afterwards.

Three further forward tests are reported elsewhere in this Supplement and were made before the corresponding spectra were computed: the discrimination between the two inequivalent L classes at 64 sites, the same discrimination at 96, and the predicted near degeneracy of L and $(\frac{1}{6}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2})$ at 72 sites, where ratios differing by 0.9% produced levels differing by 0.7%.

We note the limits of the diagnostic. It bounds the lowest odd excitation but says nothing about spectral weight, so it cannot by itself distinguish a soft mode that is bright from one that is dark; the diagonalizations supply that. It is an inequality in one direction only, so a large ω_F does not forbid a low mode—it merely fails to certify one. And the normalization by ω_G inherits the single fitted scale of Sec. , though only as a common factor across the table, so the ordering in Table I would be unchanged by any other choice of that scale.

GEOMETRY AND THE INTERACTING ENHANCEMENT OF $S(L)$

The oscillator strength has an especially transparent geometric structure. If a hexagon lies inside a wavefront of the electric-field oscillation, the alternating loop integral vanishes identically and the plaquette contributes nothing to Eq. (35).

At

$$L \parallel [111], \quad (41)$$

one of the four hexagon families lies in the wavefronts. On the 48-site cluster the family-resolved geometric factors are

$$(96, 96, 96, 0)_L, \quad (42)$$

compared with

$$(96, 96, 96, 96)_X. \quad (43)$$

The reduction in the pure geometric factor is therefore exactly $3/4$. The reduction of f_1 itself is not exactly $3/4$ because the ground-state plaquette coherences are not perfectly uniform on an anisotropic cluster. Numerically,

$$\frac{f_1(L)}{f_1(X)} = \frac{0.684}{0.880} = 0.777. \quad (44)$$

The geometric cancellation alone does not generate the anomaly. At the shortest sampled momentum along $[111]$, one family is also exactly dark, but the dominant level remains near the Gaussian photon.

The second ingredient is the interacting equal-time structure factor. On 48 sites,

$$S(L) = 0.370 \quad (45)$$

for the quantum ground state, compared with

$$S_{\text{EA}}(L) = 0.297 \quad (46)$$

for the equal-amplitude superposition over the same 9104 configurations.

A classical loop-update calculation on a 2048-site ice manifold gives

$$S(L) = 0.2488(67), \quad (47)$$

$$S(X) = 0.2538(73), \quad (48)$$

$$S(W) = 0.2475(52), \quad (49)$$

$$S(K) = 0.2467(46). \quad (50)$$

Within statistical precision the classical zone-boundary structure factor is essentially flat. The enhancement near L is therefore generated predominantly by the interacting quantum amplitudes at the physical ring point.

The 72-site soft-valley momentum

$$\mathbf{q}_v = \left(\frac{1}{6}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2} \right) \quad (51)$$

has geometric family weights

$$(36, 144, 144, 108), \quad (52)$$

so no family is exactly dark. Nevertheless its enhanced structure factor produces an f_1/S within 0.9% of the L value, and the two reconstructed levels are within 0.7% of one another.

ROKHSAR–KIVELSON DEFORMATION

We use the standard RK extension

$$H(V) = -K \sum_p (W_p + W_p^\dagger) + V \sum_p n_p^{\text{flip}}, \quad (53)$$

where n_p^{flip} projects onto a flippable alternating hexagon.

Our sign convention is such that

$$V > 0 \quad (54)$$

penalizes flippability,

$$V < 0 \quad (55)$$

rewards it, and the exactly solvable RK point is at

$$V = +K. \quad (56)$$

For state characterization we use only the derivative at the physical ring point $V = 0$. Hellmann–Feynman gives

$$\frac{d\omega_n}{dV} = \langle n | N_{\text{flip}} | n \rangle - \langle 0 | N_{\text{flip}} | 0 \rangle, \quad N_{\text{flip}} = \sum_p n_p^{\text{flip}}. \quad (57)$$

Thus $d\omega_n/dV$ is an exact state-resolved measure of the difference in the number of flippable plaquettes between an excitation and the ground state.

At 48 sites the reconstructed L level has

$$\frac{d\omega_{\text{low}}}{dV} = +0.339. \quad (58)$$

The upper L level responds with the opposite sign.

Across the four finite sizes the reconstructed levels have

$$+0.339, \quad +0.338, \quad +0.134, \quad +0.259. \quad (59)$$

The sign remains positive, but the magnitude is not size stable. We therefore do not use the census as the primary discriminator.

Exact census sum rule

The operator N_{flip} is diagonal in the configuration basis. Every flippable hexagon generates exactly one off-diagonal ring-connected state. Consequently

$$\text{Tr } N_{\text{flip}} = \text{nnz}(H), \quad (60)$$

where $\text{nnz}(H)$ denotes the number of nonzero off-diagonal matrix elements, with the same counting convention.

Averaging Eq. (57) over the complete spectrum of a sector of dimension D gives

$$\frac{1}{D} \sum_n \frac{d\omega_n}{dV} = \frac{\text{nnz}(H)}{D} - \langle 0 | N_{\text{flip}} | 0 \rangle. \quad (61)$$

On the 48-site sector,

$$\frac{1}{D} \sum_n \frac{d\omega_n}{dV} = -0.9139, \quad (62)$$

and the direct average over all 9104 eigenstates reproduces this value to 10^{-14} .

Excitations therefore lose flippability on average. There is no sign theorem for an individual eigenstate. Of the 9104 eigenstates,

$$58 \quad (63)$$

have positive census and

$$20 \quad (64)$$

exceed $+0.20$. The reconstructed L state at $+0.339$ lies in the extreme positive tail but is not unique.

The cleaner census result is the within-cluster comparison. The 64- and 96-site clusters each contain two inequivalent L -type classes at identical $|\mathbf{q}|$ and identical Gaussian energy. Their censuses are

$$64 : \quad +0.338 \quad \text{versus} \quad -0.166, \quad (65)$$

$$96 : \quad +0.259 \quad \text{versus} \quad -0.02, -0.09. \quad (66)$$

The classes that reconstruct and those that do not therefore respond with opposite signs to the same microscopic flippability probe.

Finite RK trajectory

For completeness we also follow the reconstructed level over a finite range of V . Biasing toward more flippable configurations, $V < 0$, increases $S(L)$ and softens the low level from approximately

$$1.02K \tag{67}$$

to

$$0.73K \tag{68}$$

over the range studied, while $f_1(L)$ changes by less than one percent.

This evolution is consistent with the Feynman-ratio description: the softening accompanies an enhancement of the equal-time fluctuation while the oscillator strength is nearly unchanged. We do not interpret the deformation as establishing a temporal or causal ordering between ground- and excited-state quantities.

VARIATIONAL RELAXATION OF THE RECONSTRUCTED STATE

The sublattice-resolved probe vectors

$$S_\mu^z(L)|0\rangle \tag{69}$$

span the transverse electric-field trial space. The lowest energy in this space on the 48-site cluster is

$$1.450K. \tag{70}$$

A systematic variational improvement converges rapidly:

$$1.450 \rightarrow 1.074 \rightarrow 1.034 \rightarrow 1.026K, \tag{71}$$

compared with the exact eigenvalue

$$1.024K. \tag{72}$$

Thus the reconstructed state is reached in a small collective subspace generated from the physical probe.

The fractional recovery relative to the bare optimized electric-field state is

$$\frac{\omega_{\text{bare}} - \omega_{\text{exact}}}{\omega_{\text{bare}}} = 29\% \tag{73}$$

on 48 sites. The corresponding values on 48, 64, and 72 sites are

$$29\%, \quad 32\%, \quad 28\%. \tag{74}$$

The identity of the state reached by this construction is itself a measured quantity, and it is what ties the Feynman construction to the lower branch specifically. The squared overlap of the ground-state-projected single-mode state with the lower-branch multiplet is

$$0.88, \quad 0.87, \quad 0.86 \tag{75}$$

on the 48-, 64-, and 72-site clusters; the state couples to the upper branch only through the orthogonal transverse channel. The Feynman (density-wave) construction therefore produces the lower branch, not the upper one, at every size at which the comparison can be made.

BASIS-INVARIANT PLAQUETTE DECOMPOSITION

Because the ring term is the entire nonconstant Hamiltonian in the ice manifold, every excitation energy decomposes exactly into plaquette contributions:

$$\omega_n = -K \sum_p [\langle n | W_p + W_p^\dagger | n \rangle - \langle 0 | W_p + W_p^\dagger | 0 \rangle] . \quad (76)$$

Grouping plaquettes into the four $\langle 111 \rangle$ orientation families gives a complete four-term decomposition.

The exact low level is degenerate. Expectation values in an arbitrary basis of this multiplet are therefore not physically invariant. We choose the normalized projection of the physical S^z probe onto the degenerate multiplet. This state is basis independent. An alternative alignment to the optimized single-mode state gives per-family values identical to four decimals.

The resulting decomposition is

	48	64	72
single-mode energy	1.450	1.412	1.481
exact low level	1.024	0.954	1.068
recovery	29%	32%	28%
relief, family 1	+0.080	+0.040	+0.276
relief, family 2	-0.064	-0.036	+0.002
relief, family 3	+0.088*	+0.227	+0.002
relief, family 4	+0.322	+0.227	+0.133*
dark-family share	21%	9%	32%

where $\star$ denotes the geometrically dark family for the corresponding cluster.

The 28–32% relaxation is stable across the three sizes. It is strongly family selective, but it is not concentrated in the geometrically dark family.

An earlier analysis obtained a 71% dark-family contribution by evaluating an arbitrary member of the degenerate multiplet. That result is basis dependent and is withdrawn. The corrected conclusion is a robust, family-selective reorganization of ring coherence with a dark-family contribution of 9–32%.

FEW-PHOTON KINEMATICS

Global spin reversal is an exact symmetry of the ring Hamiltonian. For an even ground state the linear S^z probe is odd and therefore couples only to odd-parity eigenstates. In gauge language this is charge conjugation, under which a state containing n weakly defined photons has parity

$$(-1)^n. \quad (77)$$

Parity excludes even photon number but does not exclude three-photon states. We therefore minimize the energy of finite-volume Gaussian photon partitions with total momentum L .

On the 48-site torus the resulting thresholds are

$$\omega_L^{(1)} = 2.03K, \quad (78)$$

$$\omega_L^{(2)} = 4.03K, \quad (79)$$

$$\omega_L^{(3)} = 5.55K. \quad (80)$$

The reconstructed level lies at

$$1.02K, \quad (81)$$

more than a factor of five below the weakly renormalized Gaussian three-photon threshold.

This rules out an interpretation in terms of a few weakly interacting Gaussian photons on the finite clusters. Because the Letter itself establishes order-one interactions at the zone boundary, the calculation is not a theorem excluding multiparticle states formed from strongly renormalized constituents in the thermodynamic theory.

OFF-POLE SPECTRAL WEIGHT AND COMPLEMENTARY PROBES

Beyond the two dominant transverse branches,

$$16\%-38\% \tag{82}$$

of the 48-site S^z spectral weight resides in higher levels absent from the Gaussian one-photon theory. The off-pole fraction is smallest at the shortest accessible momenta, consistent with recovery of the infrared photon.

Spin-reversal parity gives a clean separation of probe channels. Numerically, every even state carries linear S^z weight below

$$10^{-28}. \tag{83}$$

Bilinear operators can instead couple to the even sector, including two-particle channels, and can be accessed by probes such as Raman scattering or ultrasound [1, 2]. Magnetization probes such as neutron scattering and stray-field noise belong to the odd channel [3].

GREEN'S-FUNCTION MONTE CARLO

The ring Hamiltonian is stoquastic in the ice basis: its diagonal matrix elements vanish and every nonzero off-diagonal element is $-K$. A power method with

$$\Lambda - H \tag{84}$$

therefore converges to the ground state with nonnegative amplitudes.

We use the equal-amplitude trial state

$$|\Psi_T\rangle = \sum_x |x\rangle. \tag{85}$$

Population control is performed by comb reconfiguration at fixed walker number.

For diagonal observables such as $S(\mathbf{q})$, the mixed distribution $\Psi_0\Psi_T$ is converted to the pure distribution $|\Psi_0|^2$ by forward walking. An observable measured at time t is weighted by the number of descendants retained by the walker after a projection time T .

Convergence is benchmarked on the exactly diagonalized 48-site cluster using

$$256-2048 \tag{86}$$

walkers and

$$T = 20-160. \tag{87}$$

At $T = 20$, the forward-walking estimate of $S(L)$ is biased low by approximately 0.7%. For

$$T \geq 40 \tag{88}$$

the values fluctuate around the exact result

$$S(L) = 0.370365 \tag{89}$$

within statistical errors. Production runs use

$$T = 80. \tag{90}$$

The mixed-estimator energies exhibit a residual population-control bias of approximately

$$1.5 \times 10^{-4} \tag{91}$$

in relative units, independent of walker number over the tested range. This is two orders of magnitude below the energy differences used in the analysis.

Initialization requires care because sublattice-uniform ice configurations are frozen under the ring dynamics. Seeds are randomized using worm-constructed loop flips that first reduce the integer polarization and subsequently preserve the minimal reachable polarization exactly.

Every production calculation is gated against exact diagonalization. On 48 sites,

$$E_0 = -10.556012K \quad (92)$$

is reproduced within 0.5σ , and

$$S(L) = 0.370365 \quad (93)$$

is reproduced to every printed digit.

On 72 sites the method reproduces

$$E_0/N = -0.205690K \quad (94)$$

within 1.8σ in the correct nonzero-polarization ground sector.

Production calculations use 1024 walkers and 30 000–60 000 propagation steps. Statistical uncertainties are estimated from 16 bins.

On cubic supercells every hexagon is symmetry equivalent. The exact identity

$$\sum_p \langle W_p + W_p^\dagger \rangle = -\frac{E_0}{K} \quad (95)$$

therefore fixes the uniform plaquette coherence directly from the ground-state energy. The remaining momentum dependence of f_1 is exact lattice geometry.

The complete momentum grids contain 216 momenta on the 864-site 6^3 cell and 512 momenta on the 2048-site 8^3 cell.

LARGE-SYSTEM LANDSCAPE OF THE FEYNMAN BOUND

At the principal zone-boundary momenta the Feynman ratios are

	864	2048
L	2.142(10)	2.179(19)
X	2.660(10)	2.713(21)
W	—	2.781(10)
K	—	2.718(20)
U	—	2.736(11)

The L value shifts by only 1.7% from 864 to 2048 sites and remains 20–25% below the other principal zone-boundary momenta.

Along the radial $[111]$ direction the centroid rises monotonically toward L . On the 8^3 cell the sequence is approximately

$$0.60, \quad 1.36, \quad 1.97, \quad 2.18 \quad (96)$$

at the allowed momenta

$$\frac{k}{8}(1, 1, 1). \quad (97)$$

Thus the centroid does not possess a helium-style radial dip. Instead, the soft structure is a minimum within the zone-boundary landscape.

Representative nearby values are

$$\frac{f_1}{S} \left(\frac{1}{4}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2} \right) = 2.216(5), \quad (98)$$

$$\frac{f_1}{S} \left(\frac{3}{8}, \frac{3}{8}, \frac{5}{8} \right) = 2.265(5), \quad (99)$$

$$\frac{f_1}{S} \left(\frac{1}{4}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{3}{4} \right) = 2.484(5). \quad (100)$$

The result is a shallow valley extending away from L rather than an isolated point.

EXPERIMENTAL INTERPRETATION

The calculation does not imply that every zone-boundary feature of a microscopic quantum-spin-ice material must coincide quantitatively with the low L level of the pure ring model. Longer ring exchanges, virtual spinons, further microscopic interactions, disorder, and the material-specific magnetic moment operator can modify the spectrum.

The calculation instead demonstrates that the minimal compact gauge Hamiltonian can itself redistribute a large fraction of the finite-momentum S^z spectral weight without leaving the deconfined ice manifold.

A useful experimental pattern to search for is therefore the following: a response that is dominated by a single photon-like feature near the zone center need not remain single-mode at the zone boundary. Along $[111]$, substantial spectral weight may transfer into a lower feature while a weaker higher-energy feature remains near the continuation of the long-wavelength photon.

The exact intensity ratio is not universal. The physical neutron response coherently combines sublattice amplitudes before taking the squared modulus. The local easy axes and g tensor can therefore reweight the two branches differently and may enhance or suppress a particular feature in a given scattering geometry.

A finite cluster also produces discrete poles where the thermodynamic system may instead show a peak plus continuum. The robust experimental prediction of the minimal model is therefore *redistribution and reconstruction of finite-momentum spectral weight*, not a universal number of poles or a universal low/high intensity ratio.

SCOPE AND LIMITATIONS

The results establish the following directly:

1. a dominant reconstructed S^z level exists on all four finite clusters from 48 to 96 sites;
2. its weight fraction and scale-free branch ratio are stable across those clusters;
3. an RK flippability derivative provides an independent microscopic fingerprint of the reconstructing momentum class, the reconstructed mode gaining flippable hexagons at every size and every reconstructing momentum while every dominant level at a nonreconstructing momentum loses them;
4. the ground-state Feynman ratio, a rigorous variational upper bound, ranks the resolved momenta in exactly the order of their measured softening and discriminates the reconstructing from the nonreconstructing classes on the finite clusters;
5. GFMC establishes the large-system momentum dependence of that bound up to 2048 sites.

Several statements remain beyond the calculation.

First, the sharpness of the reconstructed level is established only through 96 spins. GFMC determines ground-state quantities and therefore the spectral centroid, not the thermodynamic linewidth. The finite-size pole could broaden into a narrow continuum in the thermodynamic limit.

Second, Eq. (8) is the pure ring Hamiltonian in the charge-free ice manifold. Electric charges are absent by construction. Longer ring exchanges, virtual spinon processes, and other microscopic terms generated in a full spin Hamiltonian are outside the present calculation. The survival and quantitative position of the reconstructed branch under such perturbations remain open.

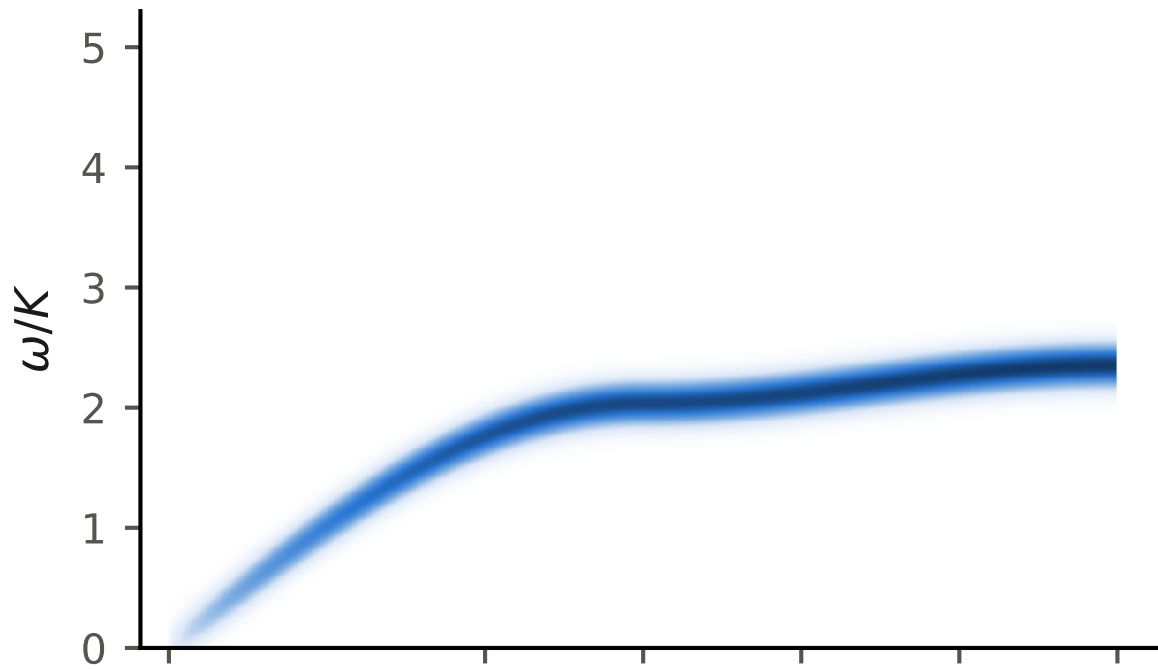
Third, the calculated observable is the sublattice-summed pseudospin response rather than the coherent material-specific neutron cross section. The experimental visibility of the low branch should therefore be tested by applying the appropriate magnetic projection for a chosen material.

ADDITIONAL SPECTRA

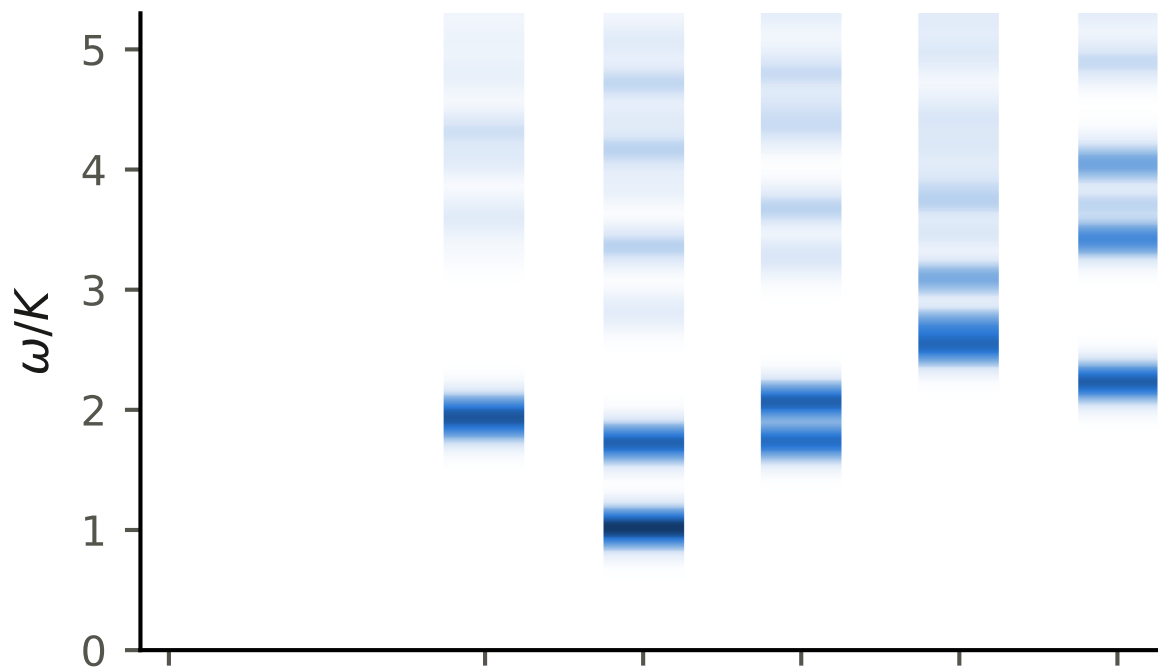
We thank the Digital Research Alliance of Canada for computational resources. The complete set of scripts generating every number, numerical gate, and figure reported in this work is included with the submission.

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- [1] Z. Fu, J. G. Rau, M. J. P. Gingras, and N. B. Perkins, Phys. Rev. B **96**, 035136 (2017).
 - [2] E. Z. Simon, A. S. Patri, and Y. B. Kim, Phys. Rev. B **106**, 064427 (2022).
 - [3] G. K. Naik, J. N. Hallén, N. C. Jayarama, R. Moessner, and C. R. Laumann, Phys. Rev. Lett. (2026), arXiv:2512.14843.

(a) Gaussian theory: $S^{zz}(\mathbf{q}, \omega)$



(b) exact compact theory: $S^{zz}(\mathbf{q}, \omega)$



(c) exact: Raman/ultrasound channel $\Phi(\mathbf{q}, \omega)$



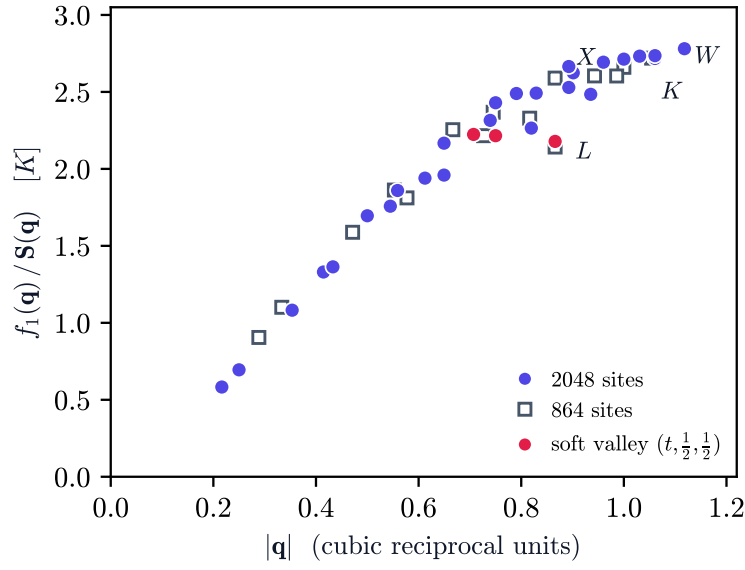


FIG. 2. The Feynman ratio at every allowed momentum star of the 2048-site supercell (circles, statistical errors; symmetry copies merged) with the 864-site grid overlaid (open squares). Red marks the soft valley $(t, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2})$. This is the complete data set behind the zone-boundary comparison of Fig. 4(a) of the main text: no path or interpolation is involved, and each value is a true eigenmode weight of its torus.

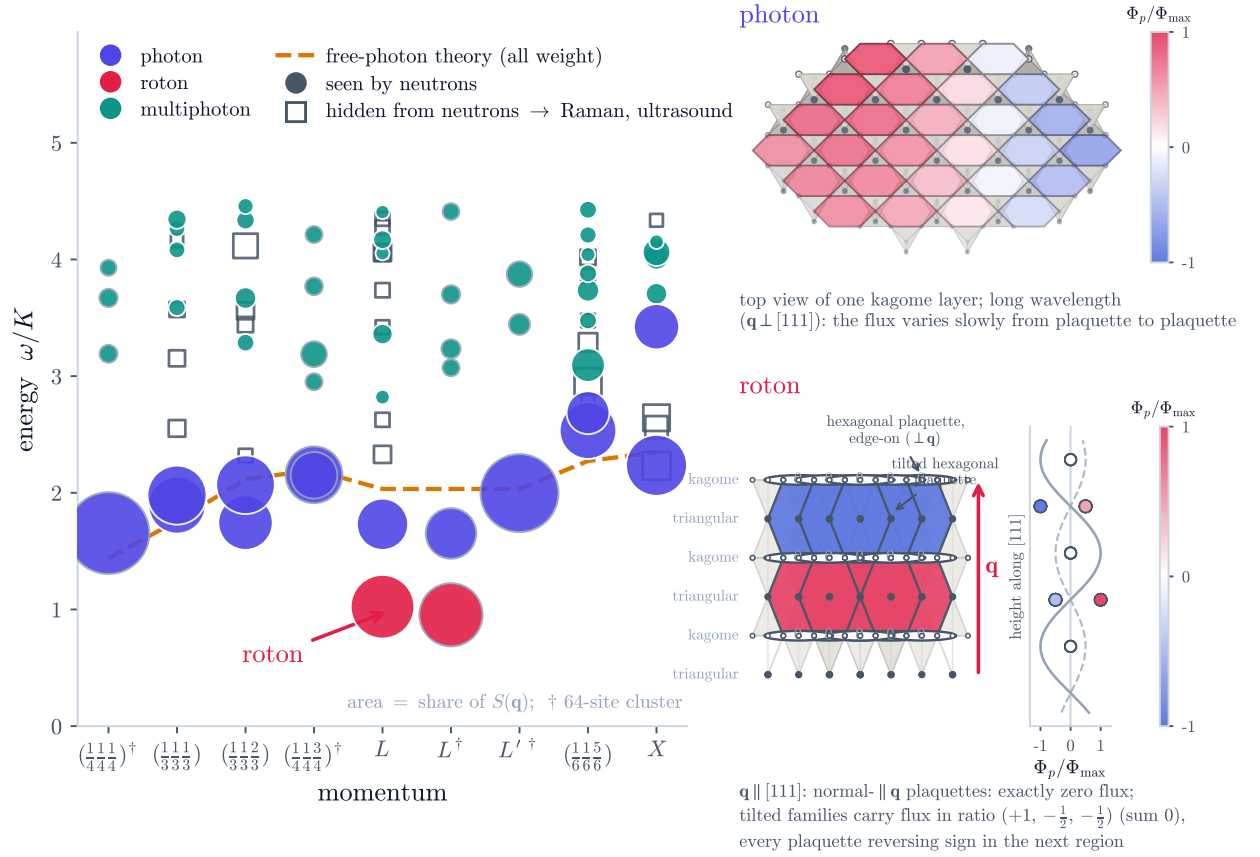
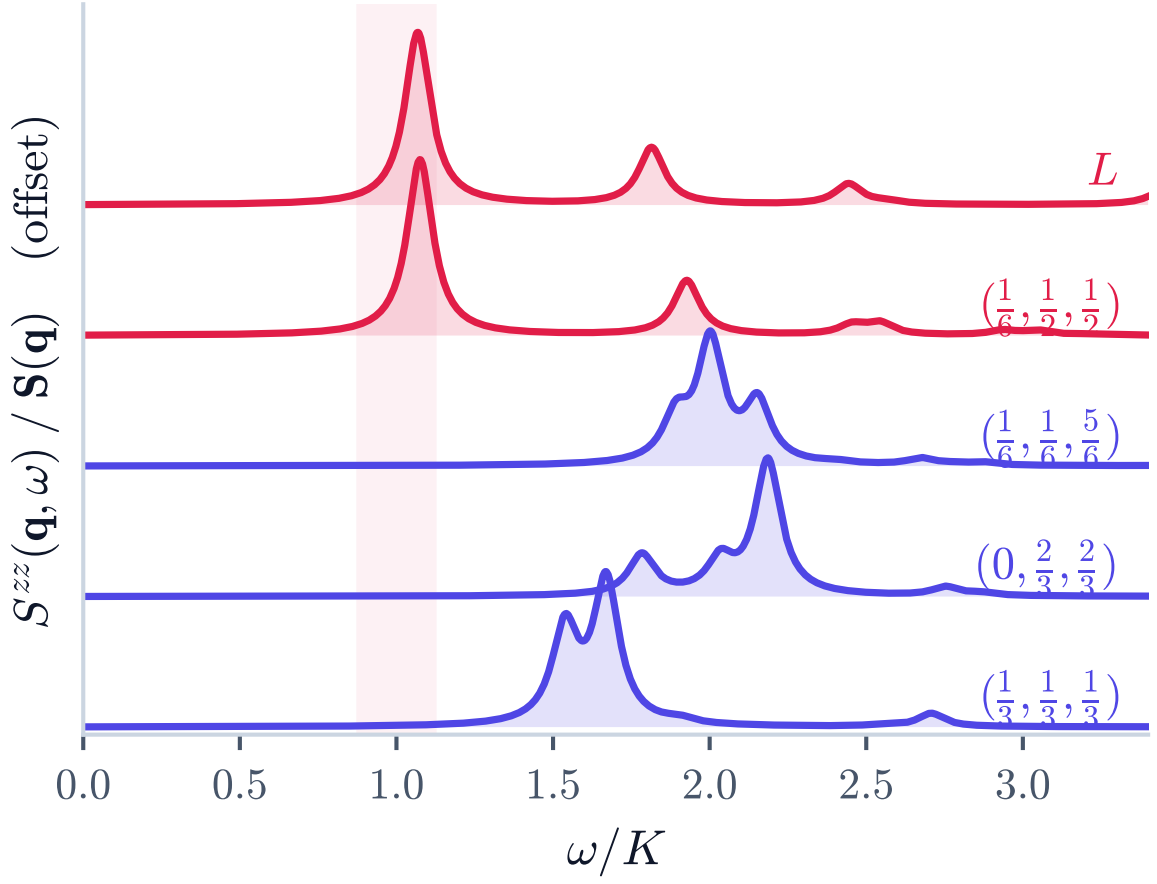
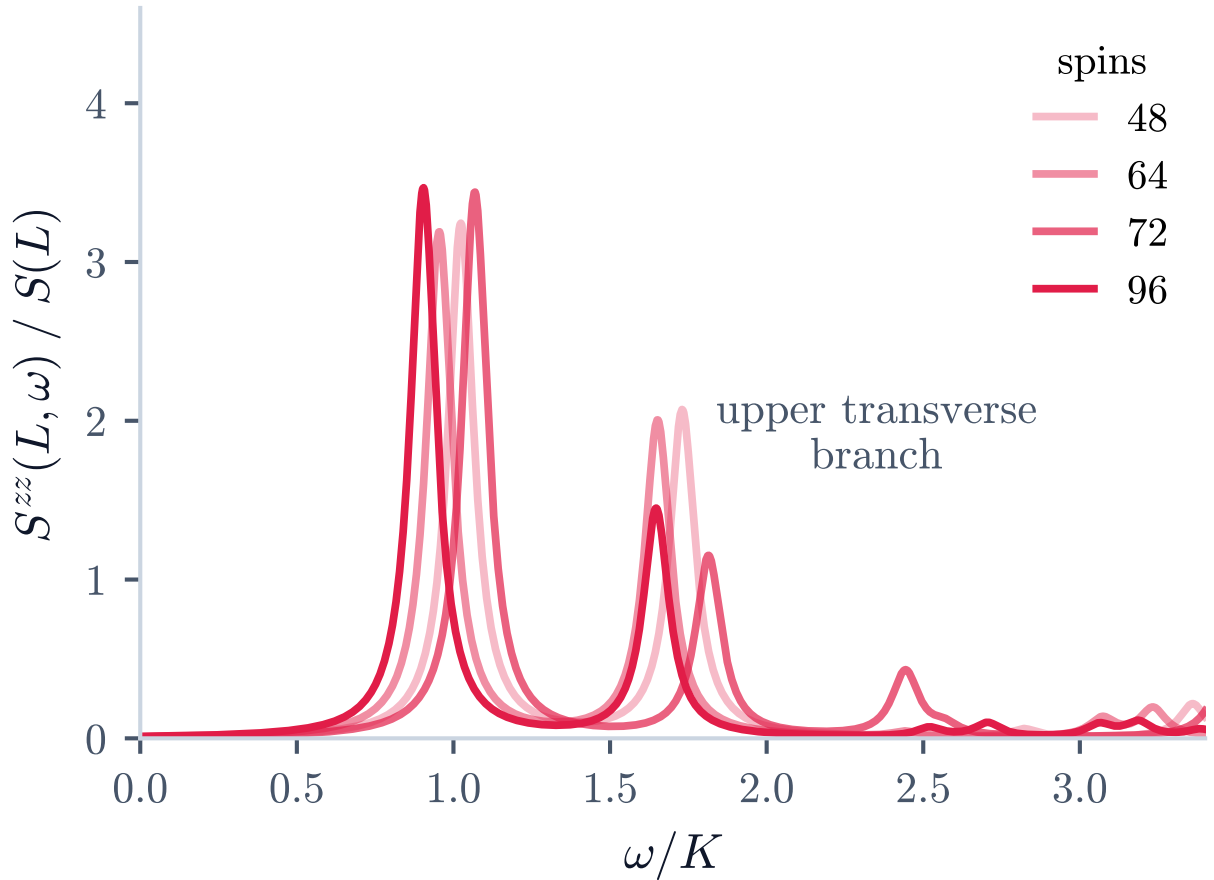


FIG. 3. Full operator-resolved finite-size spectrum and state diagnostics. Marker area represents the sublattice-summed S^z spectral weight.

(a) approaching L on the 72-site cluster(b) the L spectrum at 48, 64, 72, 96 spins

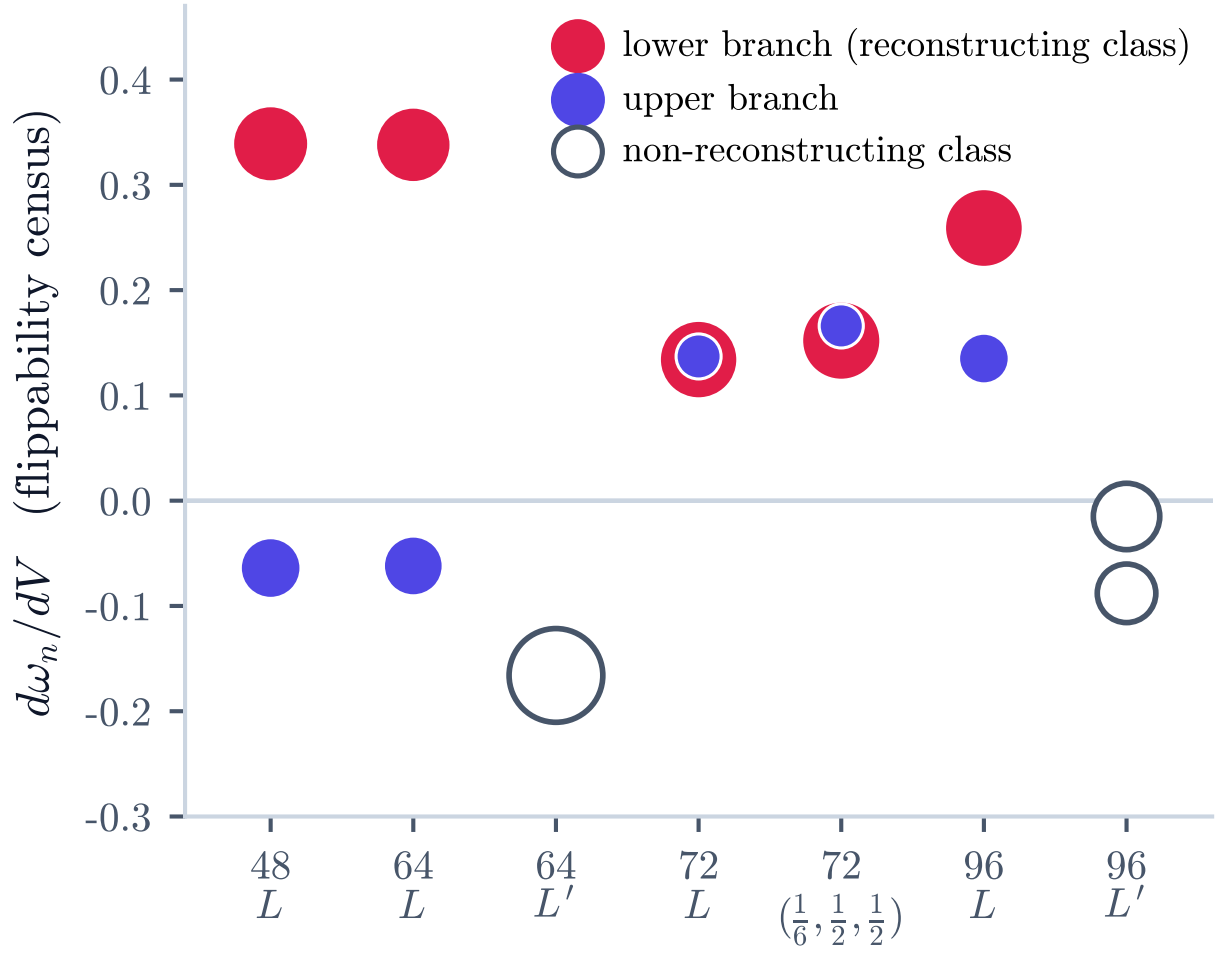


FIG. 5. Full RK deformation and flippability diagnostics for the finite-size states.

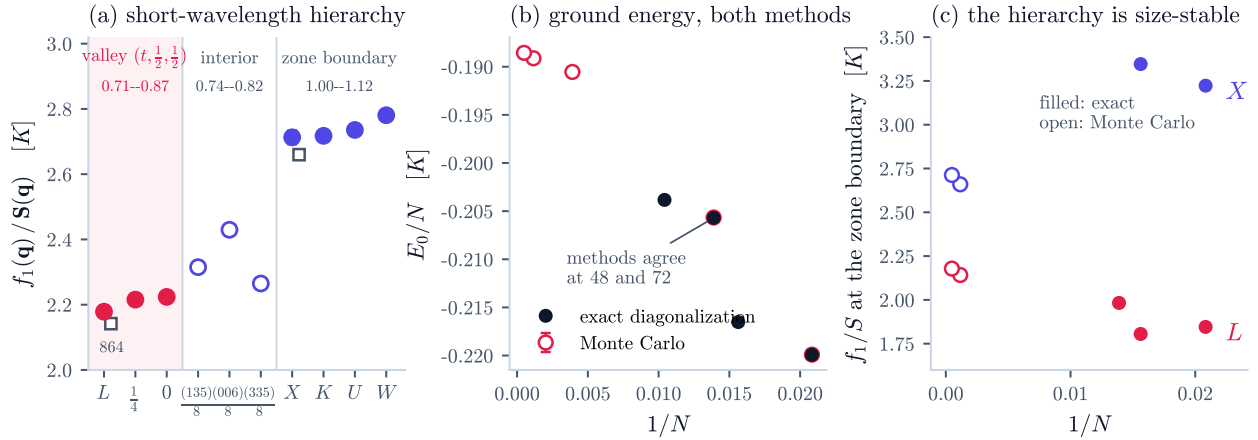


FIG. 6. Complete large-system GFMC diagnostics and Feynman-ratio landscape.